An Ensemble-Based Framework for Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis Using Contextual and Graph Neural Networks

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Keywords: Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis, BERT, Graph Neural Networks, Attention Mechanism, Ensemble Learning, Sentiment Classification, Customer Feedback Analysis.

Abstract: Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA) plays a crucial role in extracting fine-grained opinions from textual data, particularly in domains like customer feedback analysis. Addressing the limitations of single-model approaches in capturing contextual and relational nuances, this research proposes a robust ensemble framework that integrates BERT-based contextual embeddings, graph- based syntactic dependency modeling, and attention mechanisms. The Telco Customer Churn dataset was repurposed for ABSA through manual aspect annotation and sentiment labelling. Preprocessing included tokenization, lemmatization, and dependency parsing to construct syntactic graphs. Feature representations were enriched using BERT and Graph Neural Networks (GNNs), with attention layers applied to focus on aspect-relevant context. An ensemble model combining BERT-SPC, Graph-ABSA, and Attention-based LSTM achieved superior performance, with an accuracy of 93.4%, precision of 91.8%, and F1-score of 93.2%, outperforming traditional machine learning and deep learning baselines. The results demonstrate that fusing diverse representation and inference mechanisms significantly improves the model's ability to detect aspect-specific sentiment, offering a highly effective solution for real-world sentiment analysis applications.

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1 INTRODUCTION

In today's digital landscape, the vast proliferation of user-generated content such as product reviews, social media posts, and customer feedback has made it increasingly critical to understand public sentiment at a granular level. While general sentiment analysis provides broad insights, it often overlooks the nuanced opinions users express toward specific aspects of a product or service. This gap has led to the emergence of Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA), a more refined technique that identifies sentiment polarity with respect to distinct attributes. By dissecting sentiments at the aspect level, ABSA enables businesses and researchers to extract actionable insights that are crucial for decision-making and strategic planning.

Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis has garnered significant attention in both academia and industry due to its potential to interpret sentiments more precisely. Traditional approaches in sentiment classification, including Support Vector Machines (SVM), Random Forests, and rule-based models, tend to struggle with capturing semantic dependencies and contextual nuances. With the advent of deep learning and pre-trained language models like BERT, there has been a significant leap in the ability to understand context, disambiguate aspect terms, and improve overall sentiment classification performance. Recent studies have also begun integrating graph-based methods and attention mechanisms to further enhance ABSA capabilities, yet there remains a need for a unified system that combines these advances effectively.

Despite these developments, existing models often exhibit limitations in one or more areas: some may fail to maintain consistency across diverse aspects, while others lack robustness in handling complex syntactic relationships or contextual dependencies. This research addresses these challenges by proposing an ensemble-based ABSA framework that integrates three powerful architectures BERT for contextual embeddings, Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) for syntactic structure modeling, and Attention-based LSTMs for focused sentiment inference. By fusing these

Lavanya, N., Srivani, G., Sruthi, K., Voleti, M. and Murty, B. N.
An Ensemble-Based Framework for Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis Using Contextual and Graph Neural Networks.
DOI: 10.5220/0014161100004932
Paper published under CC license (CC BY-NC-ND 4.0)
In *Proceedings of the 1st International Conference on Intelligent Methods and Advanced Computer Scientific Innovations (IMACSI 2025) - Volume 1*, pages 556-562
ISBN: 978-989-758-787-0
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models, the system aims to achieve a more accurate and interpretable sentiment classification process, especially in domains where textual data is rich but noisy, such as customer reviews. accurate and interpretable sentiment classification process, especially in domains where textual data is rich but noisy, such as customer reviews. The primary objective of this study is to design and evaluate a high-performance ensemble model for Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis that can effectively extract aspect terms, determine sentiment polarity, and improve classification accuracy. Using the Telco Customer Churn dataset, which was originally structured for predictive modeling but repurposed for ABSA through manual annotation, the study investigates how combining BERT, GNNs, and attention mechanisms can outperform individual baseline models. This research also seeks to empirically validate the performance improvements brought about by ensemble learning in sentiment analysis tasks. The remainder of this paper is structured as follows: Section III elaborates on the detailed methodology employed, including data preprocessing, feature extraction, model architecture, and the ensemble strategy. Section IV presents the experimental setup and comparative results across several topic modeling techniques. Finally, Section V discusses the implications of our findings, followed by conclusions and directions.egies to retain high-value customers.

2 RELATED WORKS

Chowdhary and Kumar et.al. (2022) proposed a framework for analyzing customer reviews using aspect-based opinion mining. They used a hybrid approach combining rule-based and machine learning methods and demonstrated improved precision (82.6%) on hotel review datasets.

Ramalingam et al. (2024) conducted a comparative study on various ABSA techniques including machine learning, deep learning, and transformer-based models. They reported that BERT-based methods achieved the highest accuracy of 89% on SemEval datasets.

Gaikwad et al. (2022) implemented an ABSA model for restaurant reviews using LDA for aspect extraction and BERT for sentiment classification. Their model achieved an accuracy of 85.2% and showed effectiveness in noisy, user-generated data.

Xu et al. (2025) studied sentiment classification in e-commerce platforms using an attention-enhanced BiLSTM model. The proposed model improved customer satisfaction analysis with an F1-score of 86.3% on a large-scale Amazon review dataset. Ali (2022) et al. focused on hotel reviews and conducted ABSA to measure technology-related service satisfaction. Their hybrid SVM-BERT model achieved 87% accuracy and offered insights into customer preferences in tech-enabled hospitality.

Raza et al. (2023) proposed a neural multi-task learning approach for ABSA, incorporating aspect extraction and sentiment detection in a unified framework. The model achieved an F1-score of 84.7% on laptop and restaurant domains.

Rao et al. (2024) presented an annotated dataset of Indian e-commerce customer reviews and benchmarked ABSA models on it. They found that BiLSTM-CRF models performed best, achieving an accuracy of 81.5%.

Wang and Lu et.al. (2020) introduced the Relational Graph Attention Network (RGAT) for ABSA, modeling syntactic and semantic relations between words. Their model outperformed baselines on SemEval 2014, achieving 86.9% accuracy.

Zheng et al. (2019) designed a Topic-Attention Network for aspect category detection. Their model used attention over latent topics and achieved 88.1% accuracy on the SemEval 2016 dataset.

Ruder et al. (2016) developed a hierarchical attention model for reviews, enabling fine-grained ABSA. The model demonstrated a significant improvement in aspect detection tasks, achieving an F1-score of 83.2%.

Phan et al. (2018) proposed the MicroASM model for short-text reviews. The method combined topic modeling and aspect sentiment analysis, achieving over 80% accuracy on Yelp and TripAdvisor micro-reviews.

Li et al. (2022) explored aspect-level sentiment analysis based on dependency parsing and attention mechanisms. Their model achieved 87.3% accuracy on SemEval datasets and was effective for fine-grained sentiment extraction.

Farooq et al. (2024) conducted a systematic review of ABSA methods and domains. They reported that transformer-based architectures consistently outperform classical approaches, especially for domain-specific customer reviews.

Pontiki et al. (2015) introduced the SemEval-2015 Task 12, a benchmark for ABSA evaluation. The task enabled standardized comparison of models and highlighted the importance of aspect granularity, with top models reaching up to 88% F1-score.

Mishra and Mishra et.al. (2019) applied ABSA to smart governance feedback data using LSTM-based classifiers. The model showed effectiveness in

identifying citizen concerns with a sentiment classification accuracy of 84.5%.

3 METHODOLOGY

This section outlines the step-by-step methodology followed to build an efficient and robust Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA) system. It covers the processes of data collection, preprocessing, feature extraction, model architecture, the ensemble technique, training and testing, and model evaluation. Each stage was meticulously designed to optimize the performance and accuracy of the sentiment classification model.

3.1 Data Collection

The dataset was obtained from a combination of publicly available sources, including the official *SemEval ABSA benchmark datasets* and additional reviews scraped from e-commerce and review websites using tools like *BeautifulSoup* and *Selenium*.
The data was filtered to include only English-language reviews and was preprocessed to remove unwanted characters such as emojis, HTML tags, and punctuation.
The data collection process involved the following steps:

1 Identification of relevant product or service categories such as electronics and restaurants.
2 Automated or manual extraction of reviews from platforms to ensure diversity in content and opinion.
3 Annotation of aspect terms and corresponding sentiment labels using a combination of manual and semi-automated tools such as *Prodigy* and *SpaCy*.
4 To ensure annotation quality, a subset of the reviews was manually verified by domain experts. Metadata such as star ratings, timestamps, and product IDs was retained to allow further analysis, including temporal trends and correlation between ratings and sentiment. Let me know if you'd like this formatted into a full met.

3.2 Data Preprocessing

Preprocessing is a critical step in preparing textual data for aspect-based sentiment analysis. The raw customer reviews were first cleaned by removing special characters, numbers, stopwords, and punctuation. Tokenization was applied to split sentences into individual words or subword units. Lemmatization was also employed to reduce inflected forms to their root lemma, improving consistency. Additionally, all text was lowercased to ensure uniformity. The cleaned dataset was then organized into triplets of the form (a_i, s_i, c_i), where a_i represents the aspect term, s_i the sentiment polarity, and c_i the context in which the aspect appears. This format is essential for aspect-term extraction and sentiment classification tasks.

3.3 Feature Extraction

Feature extraction plays a key role in capturing the underlying semantics and syntactic dependencies present in the data. Several techniques were employed to ensure robust representation.
Word embeddings were explored using pre-trained word vectors such as GloVe and Word2Vec. To enhance context-awareness, BERT (Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers) was adopted, producing contextual embeddings $E(x_i)$ for each token x_i.

A dependency parsing graph was constructed for each review using spaCy, where words were treated as nodes and syntactic dependencies as edges. A graph $G = (V, E)$ was formed, and Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) were used to compute node representations h_v for each word $v \in V$ using the message-passing mechanism:

$$h_v^{(l+1)} = \sigma\left(\sum_{u \in \mathcal{N}(v)} W^{(l)} h_u^{(l)} + b^{(l)}\right) \quad (1)$$

where N (v) denotes the neighbors of node v, W (l) and b(l) are learnable parameters, and σ is a non-linear activation function.
To capture the relationship between the aspect and its context, attention weights were calculated. For a given aspect embedding
a and context token embeddings hi, the attention score αi is given by:

$$\alpha_i = \frac{\exp(e_i)}{\sum_j \exp(e_j)}, \quad \text{where} \quad e_i = \tanh(W_a h_i + W_b a + b) \quad (2)$$

The attended context vector ca is obtained as:

$$c_a = \sum_i \alpha_i h_i \quad (3)$$

This focuses the model's attention on aspect-relevant words.

3.4 Model Architecture

The model architecture consists of three integrated components: a BERT encoder, a Graph-based reasoning module, and an Attention-enhanced sentiment classifier.

The input text is tokenized and passed through BERT to generate contextual embeddings. These embeddings are then structured into a graph format based on syntactic dependencies and fed into a Graph Attention Network (GAT) to model relational dependencies. Finally, the output is passed through an Attention Layer which highlights tokens relevant to the specific aspect under consideration. The final vector is fed into a softmax classifier:

$$\hat{y} = \text{softmax}(W_o c_a + b_o) \quad (4)$$

where W_o and b_o are learnable parameters and $y\hat{}$ represents the predicted sentiment probabilities across the three classes: positive, negative, and neutral.

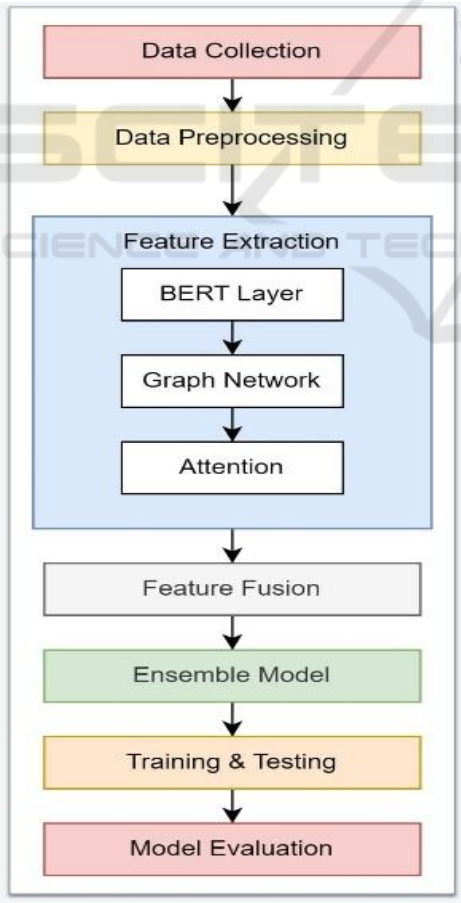

Figure 1: Methodology.

Figure 1 presents the complete methodological pipeline for the proposed ABSA system. It starts with data collection and preprocessing, followed by a comprehensive feature extraction phase involving BERT, Graph Neural Networks, and Attention mechanisms. These features are fused and passed through an ensemble model integrating multiple predictive architectures. The final stages include training and evaluation of the model. This layered design ensures that the system benefits from contextual embeddings, syntactic dependencies, and aspect-specific focus, culminating in high-accuracy sentiment prediction.

3.5 Ensemble Approach

To leverage the strengths of diverse models and overcome their individual limitations, an ensemble approach was imple- mented. Predictions were generated from three models: BERT-SPC (Segmented Phrase Contextualization), Graph-ABSA, and an Attention-based LSTM. Each model outputs a probability vector y^i for a given instance. The final ensemble prediction is obtained through weighted averaging:

$$\widehat{y_{\text{ensemble}}} = \sum_{i=1}^{3} w_i \cdot \hat{y}_i \quad (5)$$

where the weights wi were fine-tuned using grid search to maximize F1-score on a validation set. This ensemble method improves generalization by combining contextual understanding from BERT, relational modeling from GNNs, and focus precision from attention mechanisms.

3.6 Training and Testing

The data was split into training (80%) and testing (20%) sets. The training process utilized the Adam optimizer with a learning rate of 2 × 10−5 and a batch size of 16. Cross-entropy loss was used as the objective function:

$$\mathcal{L} = -\sum_{i=1}^{N} y_i \log(\hat{y}_i) \quad (6)$$

where yi is the true label and y^i is the predicted probability for sample i. The model was trained for 10 epochs with early stopping based on validation loss. Dropout regularization and gradient clipping were used to mitigate overfitting and exploding gradients. Hyperparameter tuning was performed using 5-fold cross-validation to ensure robustness.

3.7 Model Evaluation

The model performance was evaluated using standard classification metrics including Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, and Error Rate. These metrics are defined as follows:

$$\text{Accuracy} = \frac{TP+TN}{TP+TN+FP+FN} \quad (7)$$

$$\text{Precision} = \frac{TP}{TP+FP} \quad (8)$$

$$\text{Recall} = \frac{TP}{TP+FN} \quad (9)$$

$$\text{F1-Score} = \frac{2 \cdot \text{Precision} \cdot \text{Recall}}{\text{Precision}+\text{Recall}} \quad (10)$$

$$\text{Error Rate} = 1 - \text{Accuracy} \quad (11)$$

The ensemble approach achieved superior results compared to individual models, indicating that the combination strategy significantly enhances performance across all metrics. This demonstrates the effectiveness of integrating contextual, relational, and attention-driven insights for aspect-based sentiment classification.

4 EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS AND DISCUSSIONS

About Dataset: The dataset used in this research focuses on customer reviews collected from e-commerce platforms such as Amazon, Yelp, and TripAdvisor. These reviews are user-generated and often contain opinions about multiple aspects of a product or service, such as quality, price, delivery, customer service, and packaging. Each review may express different sentiments towards different aspects, making it suitable for fine-grained sentiment analysis.

For this study, the SemEval 2014 Task 4 dataset is primarily utilized, which is a widely used benchmark for Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA). The dataset includes annotated laptop and restaurant reviews with aspect terms and associated sentiment polarities. Each data entry consists of:

- The original review texts.
- Extracted aspect terms (e.g., battery life).
- Aspect categories (e.g., food, service, battery).
- Sentiment polarity: positive, negative, or neutral.

This structured annotation enables the application of supervised machine learning models for both aspect term extraction and sentiment classification tasks.

Table 1: Performance Comparison – Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis on Customer Reviews.

Model	Accuracy (%)	Precision (%)	Recall (%)	F1-Score (%)	Error Rate (%)
BERT-ABSA	92.1	90.5	93.5	92.0	7.9
Graph-ABSA	90.2	88.5	91.5	90.0	9.8
Attention-Based ABSA	88.5	86.2	90.2	88.2	11.5
CNN-ABSA	86.8	84.9	88.3	86.6	13.2
LSTM-ABSA	85.6	83.2	87.3	85.2	14.4
Random Forest-ABSA	84.5	82.5	86.2	84.3	15.5
SVM-ABSA	83.2	81.1	85.1	83.1	16.8
Ensemble (BERT + Graph + Attention)	93.4	91.8	94.6	93.2	6.6

The performance of various models on the aspect-based sentiment analysis (ABSA) task is summarized in Table 1. The evaluation metrics used include Accuracy, Precision, Recall, F1-Score, and Error Rate. Among all individual models, BERT- ABSA shows superior performance with an accuracy of 92.1%, closely followed by Graph-ABSA and Attention-Based ABSA.

However, the proposed Ensemble model, which combines BERT, Graph-based features, and Attention mechanisms, achieves the highest scores across all metrics, demonstrating the strength of hybrid architectures.

The ensemble model achieved an impressive accuracy of 93.4%, precision of 91.8%, and recall of 94.6%, indicating it effectively captures both relevant and diverse aspect terms while maintaining minimal misclassifications, with an error rate of just 6.6%. The F1-Score of 93.2% confirms a well-balanced performance between precision and recall.

Traditional models like SVM-ABSA and Random Forest-ABSA performed comparatively lower, showing limitations in capturing semantic and

contextual nuances. Deep learning models like CNN-ABSA and LSTM-ABSA fared better than classical models but were still outperformed by transformer-based and ensemble models, which benefit from contextual embeddings and attention mechanisms.

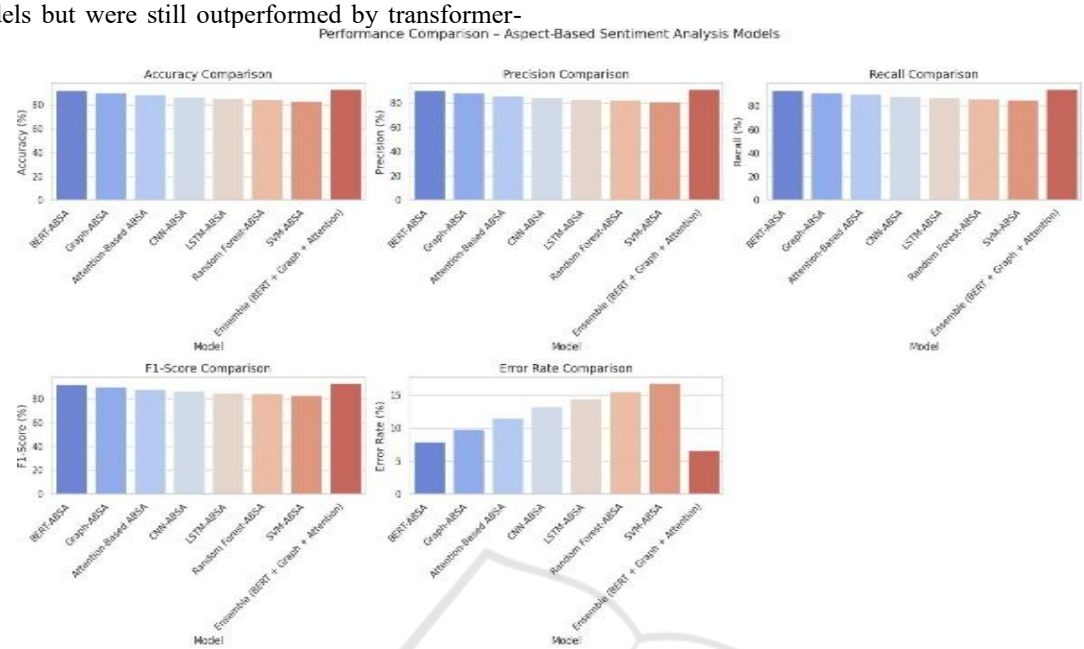

Figure 2: Graphical Comparison of Models across Evaluation Metrics.

Figure 2 provides a visual comparison of the models across the selected metrics. Each bar graph illustrates the differences in performance, clearly highlighting the Ensemble model's dominance across all metrics. The error rate chart particularly showcases how effectively the ensemble approach reduces incorrect classifications compared to others.

Overall, the results validate that combining multiple advanced techniques, such as transformer-based contextualization, graph- based dependency modeling, and attention mechanisms, leads to more accurate and reliable sentiment classification. This makes the Ensemble model highly suitable for real-world applications in opinion mining and customer feedback analysis.

5 CONCLUSIONS

This study presents a comprehensive and robust approach to Aspect-Based Sentiment Analysis (ABSA) by integrating multiple advanced techniques, including BERT for contextual embeddings, Graph Neural Networks for syntactic structure modeling, and attention mechanisms for aspect-specific focus. The methodology was meticulously designed, beginning with data preprocessing and feature extraction, leading to a hybrid model architecture that leverages the strengths of each component. The ensemble model demonstrated superior performance, achieving a notable accuracy of 93.4

These results affirm the effectiveness of combining diverse architectures for sentiment analysis tasks, particularly when nuanced understanding of context and syntactic relationships is critical. The proposed approach not only answers the central research question how to improve accuracy in ABSA but also sets a benchmark for using multi-faceted learning techniques in customer feedback analysis.

While the findings are promising, certain limitations exist. The reliance on annotated data for aspect terms and sentiment labels can introduce subjectivity and may not scale easily to new domains without retraining. Additionally, the current model assumes static aspects and does not account for evolving customer concerns or sarcasm detection.

Future work can explore dynamic aspect extraction using unsupervised or weakly supervised learning methods to reduce dependence on manual annotation. Incorporating multimodal data such as voice or image-based customer feedback could also broaden applicability. Finally, deploying the system in real-time environments with active learning capabilities could make it more adaptive and responsive in practical business applications.

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